

element of the interface. You can customise individual aspects by changing Styles and Backgrounds. To do this, go to the **Appearance > Styles** or **Appearance > Backgrounds** menu. You can always save the custom look you've created using the 'Save Theme' command in the Appearance menu.



Tons of styles to choose from here

WindowMaker supports a very eye-catching feature—dynamic backgrounds! Go to **SuSE > System** and choose from a wide range of applets including 'The Matrix'—our favourite. These applets are rather tricky to get rid of—you will have to manually kill the process to stop the dynamic



You can choose Dynamic backgrounds here



The Matrix—Coming to a Linux desktop near you!



The WindowMaker control panel lets you customise appearance

effects using the 'kill' command. (See box 'Processes in Linux') Play with this feature only if you are comfortable with this command-line tool.

Finally, use the WindowMaker Preferences application to change the interface and several aspects of window behaviour. Each option is pretty much self-explanatory. These preferences can be found in **WindowMaker > Wprefs**.

Getting new themes for WindowMaker

WindowMaker comes with plenty of themes but there are always more to be found. If you would like to add in some more themes, you can get some really interesting ones at <http://alge.anart.no/projects/wmaker/>.

WindowMaker themes come in the compressed tar.gz format. You will have to extract the themes from the compressed file into the Themes directory. The default WindowMaker Themes directory is **/usr/X11R6/share/WindowMaker/Themes**. Open a terminal (console) and uncompress the files with the following command: **tar -zxvf downloadedtheme.tar.gz**

You will find a directory by the name of **downloadedtheme.themed** inside your current home directory. Move this directory to the default WindowMaker themes directory by using this command: **mv downloadedtheme.themed /usr/X11R6/share/WindowMaker/Themes**

You should now be able to see the installed theme listed within the Themes pop-up under Appearances when you click on your desktop. Just click on the theme name to change into it.

Run Gnome over WindowMaker

If WindowMaker is getting boring and you are looking forward to working within the good old Gnome desktop, here is a simple work around in which you can switch desktops without logging out. Click on the WindowMaker desktop to get the standard

pop-up menu and select Run...

Type **'nautilus'** in the Run command dialog that comes up.

You should see some pretty interesting changes on your desktop. The WindowMaker theme will disappear and the Gnome desktop appears, with the Nautilus file browser window that shows you the contents of your home directory. Notice that the Gnome desktop comes with its own titlebar. If you would like to access the WindowMaker desktop, close the Nautilus file browser and move the Gnome desktop around by dragging its titlebar. You should see the WindowMaker desktop hiding behind it. To access your custom theme, click anywhere on the WindowMaker desktop—that should do it. You can click on any of the shortcuts on your Gnome desktop to run the corresponding application.



Gnome running over WindowMaker

Since what we pulled off here is an undocumented hack, you may face some unexpected events such as automatic wallpaper changes.

Using Metacity

If you choose Gnome at the SuSE login prompt, the default window manager is Metacity. It's quite limited as compared to WindowMaker, but at least you'll get to change the system theme and one aspect of window behaviour. Click on the 'Desktop Preferences' icon in the taskbar (the spanner and screwdriver icon). Then double-click on Metacity Setup to bring up the configuration screen.



Use Desktop Preferences to launch the Metacity configuration utility